in Beijing reported signals indicating that China did not want war, and its support might not go as far as Pakistan wanted. When Pakistani foreign minister Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto visited China in early November, Mishra noted that, unlike Pakistan, China omitted reference to Chinese support for Pakistan in 1965 in speeches. Official Chinese news reports deleted or moderated Bhutto's remarks on India and on the extent of Chinese support to Pakistan. Mishra believed that China wanted to "keep its options open." His "overall assessment" was that "China [had] adopted an attitude of restraint and [was] advising Pakistan to do the same."[204] Sources close to the Chinese embassy in London were conveying a similar message to Indian officials there.[205] Mishra also reported information suggesting China had promised Pakistan support at the UN and military equipment, but declined to intervene because of a "desire to avoid [a] clash with [the] Soviet Union."[206]

Delhi tried to ensure this Chinese support would remain limited. It welcomed Beijing finally taking its rightful place on the UN Security Council, reminding China that India had consistently taken a "one China" approach since 1949. Gandhi wrote to Zhou that India looked forward to working in "close cooperation" with China at the UN for regional and global peace. Subsequently, India's permanent representative expressed the hope that the "clouds can soon be dispersed" in Sino-Indian relations.[207]

However, over the subcontinent, more storm clouds were gathering. Gandhi's timetable was driven by different factors than Kissinger's. The military window of opportunity loomed for India. Serious skirmishes broke out in late November, and Gandhi gave General Sam Manekshaw, the chief of the army staff, the go-ahead for major action on December 4.

The Nixon administration announced it would remain neutral, but Nixon privately asserted to Kissinger, "Of course, we're not neutral."[208] The US held India responsible for the outbreak of the war, canceled loans and sales of military spares, and delayed approving food aid to India. Simultaneously, the White House suggested to America's Middle Eastern allies that, while Washington could not sell or permit them to sell American equipment to Pakistan, it would be "obliged to protest, but … [would] understand" if they supplied Pakistan with American arms.[209]

With the imminent defeat of Pakistan's army in the east, Nixon and Kissinger became convinced that India would try to destroy West Pakistan